

content is at your fingertips when you want it, and can be shooed away on a whim, to be viewed later. Beautiful.

So you're going to get plenty of entertainment online, but surely you can't subsist on home movies, no matter how cool. People are being paid good money to reel you in, and many of them have been successful in doing so—you can't give them up that easily, can you? Thankfully, you might not have to subject yourself to a TV or movie schedule despite that.

Meeting Half Way

If you were in the US, you could watch episodes of *Heroes*—the ridiculously popular new series—online. Free. Last year, the Central Broadcasting System (CBS) launched their own site called Innertube, which streamed a lot of the network's content—news reports, sports, and reruns of old shows. Innertube was a disaster—even CBS executives eventually nicknamed it “www.cbs.com/nobodycomeshere”. That, however, is beside the point.

Consider this—when the VCD first came out, was your PC your first choice to watch it on? Most likely not. Programs go on computers, movies go on TV. Yet today, you have no qualms downloading the latest blockbuster (you scurvy pirating scallywag, you) and watching it on your PC, do you? Which brings us to the point we started earlier—even content providers have realised that we look at our PCs and the Internet as sources of entertainment, so they've decided to feed it to us that way.

Ultimately, with broadcasters moving online, we'll get the best of both worlds—the reeling-in, compelling content that we're used to on TV, but without being tied to a particular time or day of the week; want a show, watch it whenever you want.

The Dream

CBS's mistake with Innertube was trying to force people to come to their site for CBS content—the tactic works on classical TV, where you flip to a broadcaster's channel to view their content, but not so on the Internet. As consumers of online entertainment, we want just one single platform from whence we can watch all the movies, music videos and TV shows that we want. And it seems clear that platform is going to be Joost.

In technology terms, Joost is an online video service that uses peer-to-peer (P2P) technology to deliver content to users. In lay terms, it's perhaps

the boldest idea in online entertainment we've ever seen. If its vision comes true, Joost will be that one-stop shop you go to for all your digital entertainment. Think of it as YouTube meets Windows Media Center meets TV. Select your channel, the show, and the episode you want to watch, sit back, and watch as your request is streamed to you via your (hopefully) fast broadband connection. You'll have to endure 30 seconds of targeted advertisements (they have to make their money, after all), but it'll be worth it.

Joost is still in Beta, while they iron out technical issues as well as copyright issues with the broadcasters, and the potential is tantalising. Some content has already made it to Joost—episodes of *Fifth Gear*, a popular British auto show, short animations by Aardman Studios (the guys behind *Wallace And Gromit* and *Chicken Run*), music videos, and so on—nothing particularly remarkable at this stage, though we should see CBS's content finally make it to Joost soon. Even Viacom has agreed to let it show content from MTV and Nickelodeon, though this isn't applicable for

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Illustration Chaitanya Surpur



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BIG BOLD AND BEAUTIFUL

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Compugame Infocom Ltd. (91) 9223328288 . Cyberstar Infocom Ltd. (91) 9342107440 . Future World : (91) 90101 30700

Website : in.creative.com